POST

What did you want to be growing up?

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Here's what I wanted to be …

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I wanted to be a "W" …

Growing up I was asked what I wanted to be when I grew up. I said I wanted to be a "W".

Why did I want to be a "W"? I don't know. I think I liked the way it looked. And I liked the way it sounded … "wahh". I still like the way it sounds … "wahh".

Kingwood High School Career Day

I'm speaking to a group of high school men in a few days. I was asked to speak about artificial intelligence, quantum computing, and being the CEO of an environmental technology start-up. I always laugh heading into these events because I feel like I should be the one in the audience. It's especially true now as I enter what I believe is the start of my career (I'd call my first 50 years training).

What will I talk about?

It's funny … at one school career event some years back I had "dressed to the nines" and started to tell a group of 3 graders about being an environmental lawyer and professor. One kid, who lived in my neighborhood, interrupted and burst out … "and he gives wheelbarrow rides!" At this point in my presentation, the whole thing got hijacked and devolved into talking about pushing kids around in a wheelbarrow, making sounds with my mouth, swerving, pretending to almost hit trees … and then finally dumping them over giggling all on top of each other on the lawn. Kids have a great way of reminding you what your profession is.

So what will I talk about to these high school men in a few days? I'm going to talk about being a "W". My Mom was so proud that I wanted to be a "W". [She was also supportive of me having a pretend friend for probably way too long named "Randy Harsman"(yes, he had a last name) and defending me when I was told that I might need special classes (apparently most kids don't want to be "W"s!).] W's may or might not make much money. W's may or may not be valued by society. But I'm going to tell these young men (after I explain to them AI) what its like to aspire to be a "W" and how to go out there, if they so choose, and be whatever letter of the alphabet they want to be. :)

Achieving my childhood dream

I started crying this morning as I was reading and thinking about this … and realized that I haven't failed … I ALREADY SUCCEEDED. I didn't even realize that I had already gotten there. I apparently had forgotten what I wanted to become.

… I have become a W.

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